theory to malign China's international image. This is a favourite tactic during boundary negotiations with India. China will allege airspace or ground violations in multiple sectors to claim that the atmosphere for talks has been vitiated. The intention is to put the opposite side on the back foot so that the Indian side spends time defending itself against such allegations during the talks and is not always able to raise contentious concerns of its own. It is important for the Indian side to have its own set of problems ready to raise with the Chinese side if they use this tactic during the negotiations.

Another Chinese tactic when setting the table for talks is to lay benchmarks for the other side to meet prior to negotiations. Thus, for instance, the Chinese kept insisting that India must talk to Pakistan on the Masood Azhar listing before raising the issue with the 1267 Committee. Or that India must explicitly reject the 'China Threat' allegation before normality may be restored in relations, as was the case in 1999 after the nuclear tests the year before. It is important to insist that there cannot be preconditions for any negotiation, and to maintain this position even if the Chinese threaten to withdraw from the talks. This is also a means of determining whether the Chinese intend to talk for form's sake alone, or desire an outcome. A more unorthodox means of preparing the field for negotiations, the use of which is growing with time, includes manipulation of the media or the political opposition in India to set out their red lines or no-go zones publicly prior to the talks. This may lead the other party to consider foreclosing certain negotiating positions because, by inference, they won't fly with the other side. Such thinking should be consciously avoided, or the Indian side might also consider making its own positions public in response, so as to signal that the Indian side is also 'locked' into its own positions.